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Author(s): Walter Conn

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Bernard Lonergan's Analysis of Conversion

Bernard Lonergan's contribution to philosophical and theological thought over the last few decades has not gone unnoticed. Indeed, considerable attention has been paid over the years to his outstanding work in such areas as cognitional analysis, epistemology, philosophical theology, and, most recently, method in theology. ⁽¹⁾ Less consideration has been given to his contributions in the field of ethics.

The one element which stands out most clearly in Lonergan's contribution to ethical thought is, of course, his analysis of the personal reality of conversion. Inasmuch as this analysis is not only strikingly original but deeply rooted in the best of traditional and modern philosophical and theological thought, it has the potential for making a major contribution to the task of clarifying the foundation for a contemporary ethic.

However, because Lonergan's analysis of conversion is complex (e.g., the distinctions and inter-relations among intellectual, moral, and religious conversions), and because different elements of it have appeared in various forms and in several places over a long period of time, ⁽²⁾ the full potential of this

⁽¹⁾ See, for example, the two volumes of interpretative and critical papers from the 1970 International Lonergan Congress, *Foundations of Theology and Language, Truth and Meaning*, edited by P. McShane (Notre Dame, Indiana: University of Notre Dame Press, 1972).

⁽²⁾ This paper will focus on the fifteen year period between *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding* (New York: Philosophical Library, 1957; designated below as *Insight*) and *Method in Theology* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1972; designated below as MT). The relationship between Lonergan's analysis of conversion and his earlier work on grace has been treated briefly in Kevin Collier, "Bernard Lonergan on Conversion",

analysis has not been readily available. It is my intention to lay out in an explicit, systematic way the key elements and basic pattern of Lonergan's developing analysis of conversion. I will also offer some constructive criticism on certain key points. Further, I hope to show that the core of Lonergan's thought contains an understanding of conscience as self-transcending subjectivity, which, once clarified, can also become an important contribution to foundational ethics. My focus will be on moral conversion, but to consider moral conversion thoroughly, I will discuss it within the context of both intellectual and religious conversion. To give some clear organization to this complex topic, I shall discuss in successive sections (after a brief look at Lonergan's general description of conversion) the three basic conversions of Lonergan's analysis intellectual conversion, moral conversion, and religious conversion, ending with some final reflections on the meaning of conscience.

In explaining his general understanding of the basic reality of conversion, Lonergan notes the distinction drawn by Joseph de Finance between a horizontal and a vertical exercise of freedom. ⁽³⁾ A horizontal exercise of freedom is a "decision or choice that occurs within an established horizon" ⁽⁴⁾ and "from the basis of a corresponding existential stance". ⁽⁵⁾ A vertical exercise of freedom is "the set of judgments and decisions by which we move from one horizon to another". ⁽⁶⁾ Lonergan explains that there may be "a sequence of such vertical exercises of freedom, and in each case the new horizon, though notably deeper and broader and richer, nonetheless is consonant with the old and a development out of its potentialities". ⁽⁷⁾ But it is "also possible that the movement into a new horizon involves an about-face; it

Dunwoodie Review 11 (Jan., 1971), 3-23. For a different interpretation, see CHARLES E. CURRAN, "Christian Conversion in the Writings of Bernard Lonergan", in McSHANE, *Foundations of Theology*.

⁽³⁾ MT, pp. 40 and 237.

⁽⁴⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 237.

⁽⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 40.

⁽⁶⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 237.

⁽⁷⁾ *Ibid.*

comes out of the old by repudiating characteristic features; it begins a new sequence that can keep revealing ever greater depth and breadth and wealth. Such an about-face and new beginning is what is meant by a conversion".⁽⁸⁾

INTELLECTUAL CONVERSION

In *Method in Theology* Lonergan says that "intellectual conversion is a radical clarification and, consequently, the elimination of an exceedingly stubborn and misleading myth concerning reality, objectivity, and human knowledge. The myth is that knowing is like looking, that objectivity is seeing what is there to be seen and not seeing what is not there, and that the real is what is out there to be looked at."⁽⁹⁾

Put most simply, this fundamental myth about knowing overlooks the distinction between world of immediacy and the world mediated by meaning. "The world of immediacy is the sum of what in seen, heard, touched, tasted, smelled, felt. It conforms well enough to the myth's view of reality, objectivity, knowledge. But it is but a tiny fragment of the world mediated by meaning. For the world mediated by meaning is a world known not by the sense experience of an individual but by the external and internal experience of a cultural community, and by the continuously checked and rechecked judgments of the community."⁽¹⁰⁾ Through intellectual conversion, one realizes that an adequate account of human knowing, of its criteria of objectivity, and of the thus known universe, must take into account not only the world of immediacy but that world and also the complex process from it to the world mediated by meaning. For knowing, from Lonergan's standpoint, is not just seeing, taking a look: "it is experiencing, understanding, judging, and believing."⁽¹¹⁾

⁽⁸⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 237-238.

⁽⁹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 238.

⁽¹⁰⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹¹⁾ *Ibid.*

And thus "the criteria of objectivity are not just the criteria of ocular vision; they are the compound criteria of experiencing, of understanding, of judging, and of believing.⁽¹²⁾" In the same way, "the reality known is not just looked at; it is given in experience, organized and extrapolated by understanding, posited by judgment and belief.⁽¹³⁾"

In contrast to this position of Lonergan and, as he says, as consequences of the myth, are the various viewpoints Lonergan names counterpositions:

The naive realist knows the world mediated by meaning but thinks he knows it by looking. The empiricist restricts objective knowledge to sense experience; for him, understanding and conceiving, judging and believing are merely subjective activities. The idealist insists that human knowing always includes understanding as well as sense; but he retains the empiricist's notion of reality, and so he thinks of the world mediated by meaning as not real but ideal.⁽¹⁴⁾

In Lonergan's view, "only the critical realist can acknowledge the facts of human knowing and pronounce the world mediated by meaning to be the real world; and he can do so only inasmuch as he shows that the process of experiencing, understanding, and judging is a process of self-transcendence.⁽¹⁵⁾"

For Lonergan the difference between empiricism, idealism and realism involve more than a merely technical point in philosophy, they constitute, "three totally different horizons with no common identical objects.⁽¹⁶⁾" An idealist "never means what an empiricist means, and a realist never means what either of them means." For example, "an empiricist may argue that quantum theory cannot be about physical reality; it cannot because it deals only with relations between phenomena. An idealist would concur and add that, of course, the same is true of all

⁽¹²⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹³⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹⁴⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 238-239.

⁽¹⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 239.

⁽¹⁶⁾ *Ibid.*

science and, indeed, of the whole human knowing. The critical realist will disagree with both: a verified hypothesis is probably true; and what probably is true refers to what in reality probably is so. ⁽¹⁷⁾

Such examples are endless, for basic “philosophical issues are universal in scope, and some form of naive realism seems to appear utterly unquestionable to very many” people. And, Lonergan continues,

as soon as they begin to speak of knowing, of objectivity, of reality, there crops up the assumption that all knowing must be something like looking. To be liberated from that blunder, to discover the self-transcendence proper to the human process of coming to know, is to break often long-ingrained habits of thought and speech. It is to acquire the mastery in one’s own house that is to be had only when one knows precisely what one is doing when one is knowing. It is a conversion, a new beginning, a fresh start. It opens the way to ever further clarifications and developments. ⁽¹⁸⁾

As Lonergan puts it in his “Introduction” to *Insight*, intellectual conversion, or “the appropriation of one’s own rational self-consciousness,”

is not an end in itself but rather a beginning. It is a necessary beginning, for unless one breaks the duality in one’s knowing, one doubts that understanding correctly is knowing. Under the pressure of that doubt, either one will sink into the bog of a knowing that is without understanding, or else one will cling to understanding but sacrifice knowing on the altar of an immanentism, an idealism, a relativism. From the horns of that dilemma one escapes only through the discovery (and one has not made it yet if one has no clear memory of its startling strangeness) that there are two quite different realisms, that there is an incoherent realism, half animal and half human, that poses as a half-way house between materialism and idealism and, on the other hand, that there is an intelligent and reasonable realism between which and materialism the half-way house is idealism ⁽¹⁹⁾.

⁽¹⁷⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹⁸⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 239-240.

⁽¹⁹⁾ *Insight*, p. xxviii.

This passage does have a certain (almost systematic) obscurity about it, but from one point of view its very value lies in that obscurity, for it seems to be something of a touchstone or litmus paper for intellectual conversion as Lonergan conceives it: certainly, anyone who has read and understood *Insight* finds the passage a model of clarity. For intellectual conversion, indeed, is the primary and central goal of *Insight*.

But if intellectual conversion results in the elimination of this fundamental myth about knowing, it consists essentially of the possession one takes of oneself as a knower, and in the realization, specifically, that the criterion of the real is the virtually unconditioned of one's own judgment. As Lonergan puts it in *Insight*, "the aim of the book is to issue an invitation to a personal, decisive act, ⁽²⁰⁾" i.e., conversion. And the crucial issue involved in this invitation is an experimental issue, but, says Lonergan, "the experiment will be performed not publicly but privately. ⁽²¹⁾" It will consist, he says, in "one's own rational self-consciousness clearly and distinctly taking possession of itself as rational self-consciousness. Up to that decisive achievement, all leads. From it, all follows. No one else, no matter what his knowledge or his eloquence, no matter what his logical rigor or persuasiveness, can do it for you. ⁽²²⁾" For "the dynamic, cognitional structure to be reached is not the transcendental *ego* of Fichtean speculation, nor the abstract pattern of relations verifiable in any Tom and Dick and Harry, but the personally appropriated structure of one's own experiencing, one's own intelligent inquiry and insights, one's own critical reflection and judging and deciding. ⁽²³⁾" Again, he says that the point at issue is personal appropriation; "the point is to discover, to identify, to become familiar with the activities of one's own intelligence; the point is to become able to discriminate with ease and from personal conviction between one's purely intellectual activities and the manifold of other, 'existential' concerns that invade and

⁽²⁰⁾ *Ibid.*, p. xix.

⁽²¹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. xviii.

⁽²²⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽²³⁾ *Ibid.*

mix and blend with the operations of intellect to render it ambivalent and its pronouncements ambiguous. ⁽²⁴⁾"

In Chapter XI of *Insight*, Lonergan has concretized intellectual conversion in the affirmation of oneself as a knower according to the basic pattern of (cognitive) operations that we have already considered in our discussion of transcendental method (minus "decision"). Lonergan says that affirmation of oneself as a knower is a judgment not of necessity but of fact, and like other judgments, rests upon a grasp of the unconditioned. ⁽²⁵⁾ Further, as in other judgments of fact,

the unconditioned is the combination of

- (1) a conditioned,
- (2) a link between the conditioned and its conditions, and
- (3) the fulfilment of the conditions.

The relevant conditioned is the statement, I am a knower. The link between the conditioned and its conditions may be cast in the proposition, I am a knower, if I am a concrete and intelligible unity-identity-whole, characterized by acts of sensing, perceiving, imagining, inquiring, understanding, formulating, reflecting, grasping the unconditioned, and judging. The fulfilment of the conditions is given in consciousness. ⁽²⁶⁾

Here the conditioned, "I am a knower," is merely the expression of what is to be affirmed—not an epistemological theorem, but simply a claim by the subject that he performs certain acts, spelled out in the "link" and already familiar to us, and these are what is meant by "knowing. ⁽²⁷⁾" And Lonergan says that the fulfilment of the conditions is "given in consciousness."

Lonergan presents a rather nuanced account of consciousness, but such an account, he insists, is not itself consciousness. ⁽²⁸⁾ Rather, "the account supposes consciousness as its data for inquiry, for insight, for formulation, for reflection, for grasp of the unconditioned, for judgment. ⁽²⁹⁾". Lonergan says that "giving

⁽²⁴⁾ *Ibid.*, p. xix.

⁽²⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 319.

⁽²⁶⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽²⁷⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽²⁸⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 326.

⁽²⁹⁾ *Ibid.*

the account is the formulating and the judging, while the account itself is what is formulated and affirmed.⁽³⁰⁾ But "consciousness as given is neither formulated nor affirmed. Consciousness is given independently of its being formulated or affirmed.⁽³¹⁾"

By experiential fulfillment, then, Lonergan "does not mean the conditioned, nor the link between the conditioned and its conditions, nor the conditions as formulated, let alone as affirmed.⁽³²⁾" He means, rather, the conditions, which are formulated, as they are "found in a more rudimentary state within cognitional process.⁽³³⁾" For "just as inquiry brings about the advance from the perceived and not understood to the perceived and understood, so there is a reverse shift," says Lonergan, "by which one moves from the perceived and understood to the merely perceived. It is this reverse shift that commonly is meant by verification.⁽³⁴⁾" In other words, for Lonergan, "verification is an appropriate pattern of acts of checking [which] are reversals from formulations of what would be perceived to the corresponding but more rudimentary cognitional contents of acts of perceiving or sensing.⁽³⁵⁾" Thus, though "in the formulation there always are elements derived from inquiry, insight, conceiving," Lonergan asserts that "in virtue of the checking one can say that the formulation is not pure theory, that it is not merely supposed or merely postulated or merely inferred, that its sensible component is given.⁽³⁶⁾"

Now, with regard to the affirmation of oneself as a knower, says Lonergan, "just as there is reversal to what is given sensibly, so there is reversal to what is given consciously.⁽³⁷⁾" And, he goes on to explain, "just as the former reversal is away from the understood as understood, the formulated as formulated, the affirmed as affirmed, and to the merely sensed, so also the latter

⁽³⁰⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽³¹⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽³²⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽³³⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽³⁴⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 326-327.

⁽³⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 327.

⁽³⁶⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽³⁷⁾ *Ibid.*

reversal is from the understood, formulated, affirmed as such, to the merely given. ⁽³⁸⁾” Therefore, Lonergan summarizes,

in the self-affirmation of the knower, the conditioned is the statement, I am a knower. The link between the conditioned and its conditions is cast in the proposition, I am a knower if I am a unity performing certain kinds of acts. The conditions as formulated are the unity-identity-whole to be grasped in data as individual and the kinds of acts to be grasped as similar. But the fulfilment of the conditions in consciousness is to be had by reverting from such formulations to the more rudimentary state of the formulated where there is no formulation but merely experience. ⁽³⁹⁾

Now it must be noted that in the judgment of self-affirmation there is a logic that places the merely factual affirmation of self as knower in a context of necessity, for, as Lonergan points out, if the contingent is supposed as a fact, it becomes conditionally necessary ⁽⁴⁰⁾. Thus, there is a peculiar logical character to the question “Am I a knower?” that renders a negative answer intrinsically contradictory, not in the words of the negation but between them and the very performance itself. The negative answer, then, is “incoherent, for if I am not a knower, how could the question be raised and answered by me? ⁽⁴¹⁾” For the negative answer is an answer; it is an affirmation which, when its implicit performance is explicated, is equivalent to “It is true that...” or “I know that I am not a knower.” Likewise, says Lonergan, “the hedging answer, I do not know, is incoherent. For if I know that I do not know, then I am a knower; and if I do not know that I do not know, then I should not answer. ⁽⁴²⁾”

Now Lonergan explains further that it is not only the conditional necessity of contingent fact that succeeds in leading the talking sceptic into contradiction, but that the Aristotelian prescription depends also on “the nature, the natural spontaneities

⁽³⁸⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽³⁹⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 327-328.

⁽⁴⁰⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 329.

⁽⁴¹⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁴²⁾ *Ibid.*

and natural inevitabilities, that go with that fact.⁽⁴³⁾” Man, in short, is empirically, intelligently, and rationally conscious, and he has no choice in the matter.⁽⁴⁴⁾ Sensations, percepts, images cannot be escaped.⁽⁴⁵⁾ And just as man cannot escape them, neither can he be content with them. Spontaneously he tries to understand. He enters, “without questioning, the dynamic state that is revealed in questions for intelligence.⁽⁴⁶⁾” He “can question everything else, but to question questioning is self-destructive.⁽⁴⁷⁾” Lonergan says that “I might call upon intelligence for the conception of a plan to escape intelligence, but the effort to escape would only reveal my present involvement and, strangely enough, I would want to go about the business intelligently and I would want to claim that escaping was the intelligent thing to do.⁽⁴⁸⁾”

But as man is not content with the flow of presentations and representations, so he cannot be content with inquiry, understanding formulation. If, above all, he wants to understand, he will want to understand, the facts.⁽⁴⁹⁾ For, Lonergan goes on,

inevitably, the achievement of understanding, however stupendous, only gives rise to the further question, Is it so? Inevitably, the progress of understanding is interrupted by the check of judgment. Intelligence may be a thoroughbred exulting in the race; but there is a rider on its back; and, without the rider, the best of horses is a poor bet. The insistence that modern science envisages an indefinite future of repeated revisions does not imply an indifference to fact. On the contrary, it is fact that will force the revisions, that will toss into the wastebasket the brilliant theories of previous understanding, that will make each new theory better because it is closer to the facts.⁽⁵⁰⁾

Fact, then, quite simply, is the criterion of cognitional self-transcendence. Thus, in delineating what he means by fact, Lo-

⁽⁴³⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁴⁴⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁴⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 330.

⁽⁴⁶⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁴⁷⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁴⁸⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁴⁹⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁵⁰⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 330-331.

nergan summarizes the essential points of his cognitional theory. Clearly, he says,

fact is concrete as is sense or consciousness. Again, fact is intelligible: if it is independent of all doubtful theory, it is not independent of the modest insight and formulation necessary to give it its precision and its accuracy. Finally, fact is virtually unconditioned: it might not have been; it might have been other than it is; but as things stand, it possesses conditional necessity, and nothing can possibly alter it now. Fact, then, combines the concreteness of experience, the determinateness of accurate intelligence, and the absoluteness of rational judgment. It is the natural objective of human cognitional process. It is the anticipated unity to which sensation, perception, imagination, inquiry, insight, formulation, reflection, grasp of the unconditioned, and judgment make their several complementary contributions. ⁽⁵¹⁾

And, indeed, the fundamental power of transcendental method, the radical realization of intellectual conversion, is that we are committed, inexorably, to the realm of fact. We are committed, says Lonergan, "not by knowing what it is and that it is worth while, but by an inability to avoid experience, by the subtle conquest in us of the Eros that would understand, by the inevitable aftermath of that sweet adventure when a rationality identical with us demands the absolute, refuses unreserved assent to less than the unconditioned and, when that is attained, imposes upon us a commitment in which we bow to an immanent Anagke. ⁽⁵²⁾"

Now just as the intellectually converted subject discovers rational consciousness' virtually unconditioned as the criterion of the real, so he also discovers that while rational consciousness criticizes everything, including the achievement of science, it cannot criticize itself. For he discovers, as Lonergan says, that "the critical spirit can weigh all else in the balance, only on the condition that it does not criticize itself. It is a self-assertive spontaneity that demands sufficient reason for all else but offers

⁽⁵¹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 331.

⁽⁵²⁾ *Ibid.*

no justification for its demanding.⁽⁵³⁾” And this rational consciousness that the subject discovers is his own; it is not some item on sale at the discount center which momentarily attracts his curiosity; he is already involved, engaged, committed. For, as Lonergan says, “the disjunction between rationality and non-rationality is an abstract alternative but not a concrete choice. Rationality,” he continues, “is my very dignity, and so closely to it do I cling, that I would want the very best of reasons for abandoning it. Indeed, I am so much one with my reasonableness that, when I lapse from its high standards, I am compelled either to repent my folly or to rationalize it.⁽⁵⁴⁾”

Self-affirmation, then, as one concrete form of intellectual conversion, is a judgment of fact. In it the subject affirms that, in fact, he does perform certain operations within a definite pattern, and that this pattern of operations is knowing. And because the evidence for this judgment is given and grasped in the immediacy of consciousness, it is, on the most basic level, unrevisable and, indeed, finally inescapable, as we have seen in the contradiction of self-negation. Through the judgment of self-affirmation, then, Lonergan helps the subject to discover and realize natural spontaneities and inevitabilities that constitute the possibility and nature of knowing, not by demonstrating in some abstract, “objective” way that one can know, but by concretely and pragmatically engaging him in the process of knowing.⁽⁵⁵⁾ And, concludes Lonergan, in the last resort one cannot “reach a deeper foundation than that pragmatic engagement. Even to seek it involves one in a vicious circle; for if one seeks such a foundation, one employs one’s cognitional process; and the foundation to be reached will be no more secure or solid than the inquiry utilized to reach it.⁽⁵⁶⁾”

The central aim of *Insight*, then, is the self-appropriation of the subject as a knower, the study of human understanding (as the subtitle indicates) but in the concrete, existential instance of

⁽⁵³⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 332.

⁽⁵⁴⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁵⁵⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁵⁶⁾ *Ibid.*

one's own understanding; in short, the intellectual conversion of the subject.

MORAL CONVERSION

We have seen that the affirmation of oneself as an empirically, intelligently, and rationally conscious subject is a special and crucial instance of cognitional self-transcendence, a precise formulation of intellectual conversion in which the criterion of the real is recognized in the virtually unconditioned judgment. In the same way, the further affirmation and appropriation of oneself as not only an empirically, intelligently, and rationally but also morally (or rationally self-) conscious subject is the central and strategic instance of moral self-transcendence, the recognition and choice of oneself as a free and responsible originator of value. Such is the substance, the issue at stake in moral conversion. While the precise meaning of "self-appropriation" is not always clear with Lonergan, it does seem certain that even in *Insight*, where his principal concern is intellectual conversion, the "self-appropriation" to which Lonergan invites his readers is the appropriation of one's rational self-consciousness; the crucial, experimental issue, he says there, consists "in one's own rational self-consciousness clearly and distinctly taking possession of itself as rational self-consciousness.⁽⁵⁷⁾" Now, as Lonergan makes clear in Chapter XVIII of *Insight*, "rational self-consciousness" is the consciousness of a subject on the level of deliberating and deciding.⁽⁵⁸⁾ The subject on this level is also referred to as being "morally self-conscious."⁽⁵⁹⁾ And even while the larger context of the above quote from the "Introduction" seems to be that of intellectual conversion, i.e., the appropriation or taking possession of oneself as an experiencer, understander, and judger, its more immediate context seems to include oneself as a decider, also, for the quote follows directly upon a reference to "the personally

⁽⁵⁷⁾ *Insight*, p. xviii.

⁽⁵⁸⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 613.

⁽⁵⁹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 599.

appropriated structure of one's own experiencing, one's own intelligent inquiry and insights, one's own critical reflection and judging and deciding.⁽⁶⁰⁾ And whereas Lonergan speaks of reduplicating the structure of experiencing, understanding, and judging as "self-knowledge" in *Collection's* "Cognitive Structure,"⁽⁶¹⁾ the "self-appropriation" that constitutes the transcendental method of *Method in Theology* also includes deciding in the structure of operations to be reduplicated.⁽⁶²⁾ So it seems that while by "self-appropriation" Lonergan sometimes means the possession one takes of oneself in intellectual conversion, "self-appropriation" more consistently and properly means the possession, beyond self-knowledge, that the conscious subject takes of himself not only as experiencer, understander, and judge, but also and especially as decider. In this sense "self-appropriation" is equivalent to moral conversion, and it is in this sense that I will use it here.

Structurally, if self-knowledge (self-affirmation as knower) is the "conjunction of (1) experiencing experience, understanding and judging, (2) understanding one's experience of experience, understanding, and judging, and (3) judging one's understanding of experience, understanding, and judging to be correct,⁽⁶³⁾" then a methodical approach to self-appropriation may be seen as a "fourfold matter of (1) experiencing one's experiencing, understanding, judging, and deciding, (2) understanding the unity and relations of one's experienced experiencing, understanding, judging, and deciding, (3) affirming the reality of one's experienced and understood experiencing, understanding, judging, deciding and (4) deciding to operate in accord with the norms immanent in the spontaneous relatedness of one's experienced, understood, affirmed experiencing, understanding, judging and deciding."⁽⁶⁴⁾

As these two outlines indicate, self-appropriation adds to the affirmation of one's self as a knower both the affirmation and the

⁽⁶⁰⁾ *Ibid.*, p. xviii.

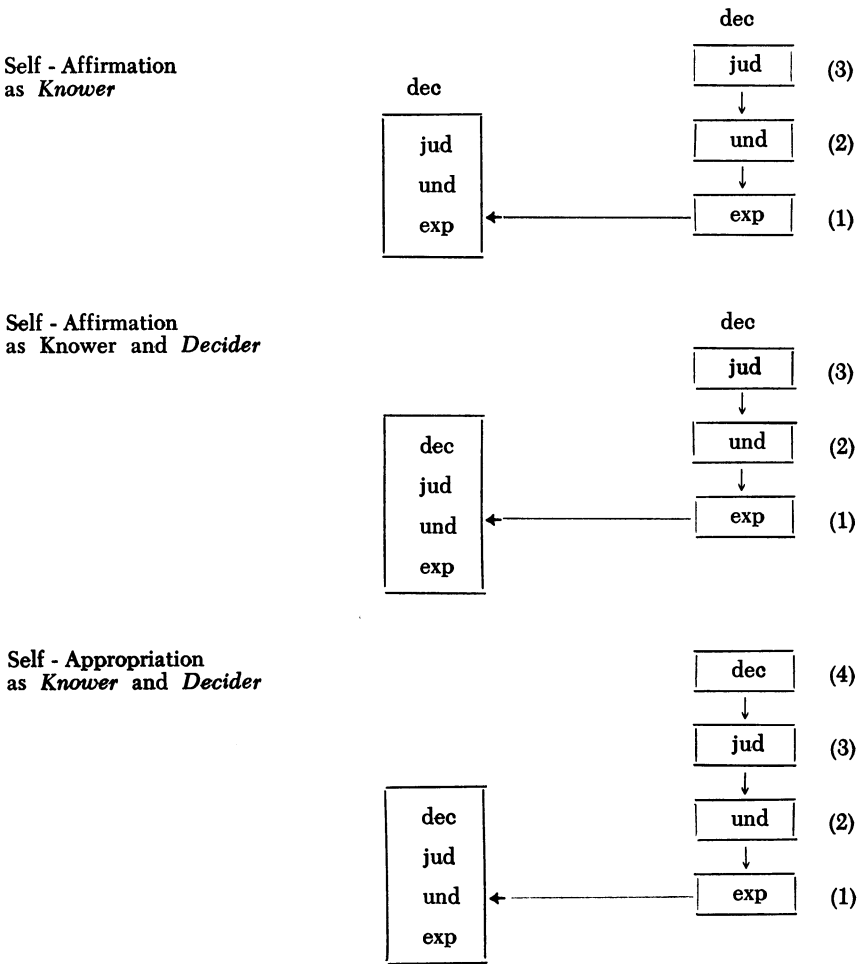
⁽⁶¹⁾ *Collection*, pp. 224-225.

⁽⁶²⁾ MT, pp. 14-15.

⁽⁶³⁾ *Collection*, p. 224.

⁽⁶⁴⁾ MT, p. 15.

choice of oneself as a free and responsible decider as well as knower. ⁽⁶⁵⁾



Now the point of this highly formalized elaboration is not to suggest that moral conversion always follows such an explicit

⁽⁶⁵⁾ The language of the second outline is appropriate to its original context within a discussion of transcendental method; in (4), “operate” might well be replaced by “live” in a more existential setting.

form (indeed, we shall want to distinguish between the appropriation of moral conversion simply and its more technically explicit formulation in transcendental method), but merely to indicate the structure (whether it be explicit or merely implicit) of the moral conversion we will be discussing from the standpoint of philosophical analysis. For as moral conversion is an expansion of the appropriation of one's interiority, one's subjectivity that we analyzed in the affirmation of one's self as a knower, it, like intellectual conversion, resembles theory in its technical expression, though it occurs in the realm of interiority rather than theory. ⁽⁶⁶⁾

While the appropriation of one's moral consciousness may be considered as the full goal of the critical exigence that leads initially to the appropriation of one's interiority in the form of intellectual conversion, and as such is included by Lonergan as part of transcendental method, its power, range and depth is not to be minimized as having to do only with the question of method. For familiarity with transcendental method on a merely conceptual level is not the issue at stake here. At the dynamic heart of transcendental method at every level is a preconceptual performance, a conversion. Just as the intellectual conversion called "self-affirmation as knower," though part of transcendental method, is not something to be just read about in a book, so taking possession of one's moral consciousness, though part of transcendental method, is an existential performance. (I do not mean that it occurs only within the context of transcendental method.)

Further, in its full sense, moral conversion is performance not just as discovery, recognition, affirmation of one's moral consciousness in all its implications, but also and especially as the active decision to accept fully the exigence of that moral consciousness, the existential choice of oneself as a free and responsible originator of value in one's decisions and choices. Transcendental method in this sense, I repeat, is not attained by simply reading books, listening to lectures, attending courses, following doctoral programs. All these may help, but the full

⁽⁶⁶⁾ MT, p. 83.

self-appropriation of transcendental method is essentially an entirely personal achievement, each person performs it for himself. Further, though part of transcendental method, self-appropriation or moral conversion, like intellectual conversion, must not be thought of as something proper only to philosophy, science or scholarship; its import and ramifications extend to the whole of concrete living; it is the source, indeed, of authentic subjectivity.

Put most simply, but in a way that gets to the core of the issue, moral conversion, says Lonergan, "changes the criterion of one's decisions and choices from satisfactions to values."⁽⁶⁷⁾

As Lonergan puts it, "by deliberation, evaluation, decision, action, we can know and do, not just what pleases us, but what is truly good, worth while."⁽⁶⁸⁾ In other words, on the topmost level of consciousness the subject is "at once practical and existential: practical inasmuch as he is concerned with concrete courses of action; existential inasmuch as control includes self-control, and the possibility of self-control involves responsibility for what he makes of himself."⁽⁶⁹⁾ As Lonergan points out, however, self-control can be grounded in quite different personal realities. If that ground be mere selfishness, says Lonergan, "then the process of deliberation, evaluation, decision is limited to determining what is most to one's advantage, what best serves one's interests, what on the whole yields a maximum of pleasure and a minimum of pain."⁽⁷⁰⁾

But self-control can, at the opposite pole, also proceed from a concern with value, and in the measure that one's living is a response to value, in that measure one effects a real self-transcendence⁽⁷¹⁾. In every decision, every action, every achievement that is a response to value and not the mere gratification of personal desire, in other words, one moves beyond, transcends himself in

⁽⁶⁷⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 240.

⁽⁶⁸⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 35.

⁽⁶⁹⁾ BERNARD LONERGAN, "Faith and Beliefs" (paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the American Academy of Religion, Newton, Mass., October, 1969), p. 6. (Mimeographed).

⁽⁷⁰⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁷¹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 7.

a real way. And to the degree that one achieves such self-transcendence, one becomes a source, a principle, as Lonergan puts it, of "benevolence and beneficence, capable of genuine collaboration and of true love."⁽⁷²⁾ But, as Lonergan is quick to add, it is one thing to transcend oneself in response to value "occasionally, by fits and starts. It is another to do it regularly, easily, spontaneously."⁽⁷³⁾ For only from a long process of development involving every facet of the conscious human subject does there emerge the *sustained* self-transcendence of the virtuous man. The crucial factor in this long process of moral (or personal, human) development, of course, is the transformation of horizon, the shift in criterion of choice that Lonergan names moral conversion.

While Lonergan calls moral conversion (like the other conversions) a "morality of self-transcendence,"⁽⁷⁴⁾ it is neither the only nor just any instance of the self-transcendence that is achieved in response to value. Just as any judgment (and not only the judgment grounding intellectual conversion) achieves cognitive self-transcendence, so every genuine decision and good act in response to value achieves real self-transcendence. Thus one does not need to be morally converted to realize self-transcendence in particular choices any more than one needs to be intellectually converted to attain cognitive self-transcendence in given instances of true judgment. But, also, as intellectual conversion is a special instance of cognitive self-transcendence, so, too, the choice of oneself as a free and responsible originator of value is a special instance of moral or real self-transcendence — special in the sense that it grounds, provides the programmatic base for the development of the sustained moral self-transcendence of human authenticity.

Lawrence Kohlberg has pointed out from a psychological perspective on moral development that mature moral judgments of a principled conscience require such a complex level of cognitive and affective development that even with the minority of

⁽⁷²⁾ MT, p. 35.

⁽⁷³⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁷⁴⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 241.

people who reach it, the psychological maturity for such a principled conscience emerges only in young adulthood.⁽⁷⁵⁾ Inasmuch as Kohlberg restricted himself for the most part to a consideration of moral judgement, it seems clear that at least such a complex development is required for moral conversion. For moral conversion is a matter of not only a judgment of a principled conscience, but also a choice, and that judgment and choice about not just anything, but about and of the self as a free and responsible subject. If moral conversion, then, is the beginning of a deliberate movement toward an ever more complete authenticity, it is also the end of a process of many years of fundamental developments that form the very condition for the possibility of a radical moral conversion.

The fact is that man's moral life is in no way given as an accomplished fact. From the very beginning in the early years of childhood, as we have seen, even the most rudimentary moral sense must be developed. Thus, even the emergence (let alone the conversion) of what Lonergan calls the fourth level of responsible consciousness, the level of deliberation, evaluation and choice, is a slow process that only begins to occur between the ages of three and six.⁽⁷⁶⁾ It is then, says Lonergan, summarizing the development of the period, that

the child's earlier affective symbiosis with the mother is complemented by relations with the father who recognizes in the child a potential person, tells him or her what he or she may and may not do, sets before him or her a model of human conduct, and promises to good behavior the later rewards of the self-determining adult. So the child gradually enters the world mediated by meaning and regulated by values and, by the age of seven years, is thought to have attained the use of reason⁽⁷⁷⁾.

Such use of reason is, of course, only a bare minimum, as Piaget and Kohlberg have amply indicated, and is, as Lonergan

⁽⁷⁵⁾ See, for example, "The Adolescent as a Philosopher", *Daedalus* 100 (Fall, 1971), 1071.

⁽⁷⁶⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 121.

⁽⁷⁷⁾ *Ibid.*; see ANTOINE VERGOTE, *Psychologie religieuse* (Brussels: Des-sart, 1966), pp. 192 ff.

says, only the beginning of human authenticity.⁽⁷⁸⁾ It is a seed that must develop over many years with careful nurture. In childhood, as Lonergan says, we must be “persuaded, cajoled, ordered, compelled to do what is right.⁽⁷⁹⁾” But as the being of the subject is becoming, one slowly and painfully becomes oneself. And as each year, month, day passes, “the subject has more and more to do with his own becoming.⁽⁸⁰⁾” He also, of course, wants more and more to do with his becoming. And because, as Lonergan points out, “development is a matter of increasing the number of things that one does for oneself, that one decides for oneself, that one finds out for oneself,⁽⁸¹⁾” the young subject, resenting adult interference, wants to do, decide and discover more and more for himself, despite the fact that his desire for doing and deciding quickly outruns his ability for reasonable judgment and thus responsible deciding. This fact seems responsible for a good measure of the tragic quality of human existence, for, as Lonergan puts it in *Insight*, “man develops biologically to develop psychically, and he develop psychically to develop intellectually and rationally. The higher integrations suffer the disadvantage of emerging later. Then are the demands of finality upon us before they are realities in us. They are manifested more commonly in aspiration and in dissatisfaction with oneself than in the rounded achievement of complete genuineness, perfect openness, universal willingness.⁽⁸²⁾” And during the process of self-development “one has to live and make decisions in the light of one’s undeveloped intelligence and under the guidance of one’s incomplete willingness.⁽⁸³⁾” Indeed, it is for this reason that “one has to have passed well beyond the turmoil of puberty before becoming fully responsible in the eyes of the law.⁽⁸⁴⁾”

But, at the same time, “as our knowledge of human reality increases, as our responses to human values are strengthened

⁽⁷⁸⁾ MT, p. 121.

⁽⁷⁹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 240.

⁽⁸⁰⁾ *Collection*, p. 241.

⁽⁸¹⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁸²⁾ *Insight*, p. 625.

⁽⁸³⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 627.

⁽⁸⁴⁾ MT, p. 121.

and refined," parents and teachers and superiors of one kind or another more and more let us do, decide, and discover things on our own, leaving "us to ourselves so that our freedom may exercise its ever advancing thrust toward authenticity. ⁽⁸⁵⁾".

And in such a thrust toward authenticity there is the possibility of moral conversion, of the concrete human subject reaching that critical point, that existential moment within a long and gradual process of development and increasing autonomy when he discovers that his judging and choosing affect himself, the subject, no less than the objects of his judgments and choices, and that it is up to himself to decide for himself what he is to make of himself. ⁽⁸⁶⁾ Such discovery, such realization of oneself as an originator of value who creates himself in every deed, decision and discovery of life that all accumulate as dispositions, habits and character determining what one's very subjectivity is and is to be, demands that the subject through a radical exercise of his fundamental, vertical freedom take hold of and responsibly choose himself precisely as the originating value he has realized himself to be (in which case originating and terminal values coincide). ⁽⁸⁷⁾ Such a radical appropriation of oneself as a free and responsible creator of value establishes an entirely new horizon defined by the choice of value as criterion of decision and choice, a criterion, indeed, of one's living. Even before this conversion, this discovery and choice of oneself as responsibly free, and the consequent reorientation and reorganization of one's priorities and values, the self is its own creator; the essential point to note about moral conversion is that after conversion the self's creation of itself is open-eyed and deliberate. As Lonergan puts it, "autonomy decides what autonomy is to be. ⁽⁸⁸⁾".

And even if, before the discovery of ourselves as moral persons, we have made ourselves what we are without any significant awareness of what we were doing, still, after that discovery, it is to a large extent possible to recreate ourselves in

⁽⁸⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 240.

⁽⁸⁶⁾ *Ibid.*, also see *Collection*, p. 242.

⁽⁸⁷⁾ See MT, p. 51.

⁽⁸⁸⁾ *Collection*, p. 242.

the light of better knowledge and fuller responsibility. To refuse the opportunity of such re-creation of self offers no escape, for it means, ultimately, the assumption of responsibility, whether we want it or not, for whatever we have inadvertently made of ourselves in the past. ⁽⁸⁹⁾ The opposite to the open-eyed, deliberate control of the self-appropriated autonomy emerging from moral conversion, is, quite simply, drifting. As Lonergan puts it,

the drifter has not yet found himself; he has not yet discovered his own deed and so is content to do what everyone else is doing; he has not yet discovered his own will and so he is content to choose what everyone else is choosing; he has not yet discovered a mind of his own and so he is content to think and say what everyone else is thinking and saying; and others too are apt to be drifters, each of them doing and choosing and thinking and saying what others happen to be doing, choosing, thinking, saying. ⁽⁹⁰⁾

The moral conversion we have discussed here must not be confused, of course, with moral perfection, of which it falls far short. ⁽⁹¹⁾ To opt for a new horizon, to choose a new criterion of decision is one thing; to live within that horizon fully, to choose consistently according to that new criterion is another. As Lonergan says, "deciding is one thing, doing another. ⁽⁹²⁾" It is, indeed, difficult enough for one to overcome the resistance that he spontaneously throws up against the possibility of conversion, of moving into a radically new horizon. For horizons define not abstractions but the shape of concrete living. And for anyone to experience, anticipate, or even seriously contemplate a change in his style of concrete living that has up until now more or less successfully synthesized and integrated the key elements of his personality — unconscious as well as conscious, practical as well as interpersonal — is to invite an experience of anxiety or dread. And the spontaneous and resourceful resistance that this dread

⁽⁸⁹⁾ See "Notes on Existentialism", Sec. IV, p. 11.

⁽⁹⁰⁾ *Collection*, p. 242.

⁽⁹¹⁾ MT, p. 240.

⁽⁹²⁾ *Ibid.*

releases not only attempts to defend the given horizon that is being challenged, but necessarily does so from within it, employing a logic of common sense based on its own meanings and values that is unimpeachable on its own grounds.⁽⁹³⁾ From the viewpoint of logic, then, conversion to a radically new horizon is a leap, and such a leap is necessarily effected not by logical argument, but by more concrete and symbolic means that do not attack logical defenses but reach immediately to the very core of horizon, tunneling directly to its imaginative and affective ground, the "heart" of the subject.

As difficult as such a leap of conversion may be, however, it is, as I have already suggested, more a beginning than an end. As Lonergan has put it, "in this life the critical point is never transcended."⁽⁹⁴⁾ For, again, "it is one thing to decide what one is to make of oneself; ... it is another to execute the decision. Today's resolutions do not predetermine the free choice of tomorrow, of next week, or next year, or ten years from now. What has been achieved," says Lonergan, "is always precarious: it can slip, fall, shatter. What is to be achieved can be ever expanding, deepening. To meet one challenge is to effect a development that reveals a further and graver challenge."⁽⁹⁵⁾

Moral conversion is not moral perfection. But meeting the challenge of moral conversion not only brings the meaning of personal responsibility into sharp focus, but also highlights in an intensely personal fashion the ideal of authentic human living, as well as the distance between it and one's present achievement. Thus moral conversion is not so much an achievement as a call to commitment. For insofar as through conversion one realizes how drastically his effective freedom is limited,⁽⁹⁶⁾ he must commit himself to the seemingly endless task of conquering the jungle of his personal prejudices and biases, of developing his knowledge of concrete human realities and possibilities, of scrutinizing his intentional responses to values and their implicit

⁽⁹³⁾ See "Notes on Existentialism", Sec. IV, pp. 10-11.

⁽⁹⁴⁾ *Collection*, p. 242.

⁽⁹⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 242-243.

⁽⁹⁶⁾ See *Insight*, pp. 619-633.

scale of preferences, of listening to criticism and protest, and of learning from others. ⁽⁹⁷⁾ For, as Lonergan says, "moral knowledge is the proper possession only of morally good men and, until one has merited that title, one has still to advance to learn. ⁽⁹⁸⁾" And even after "meriting the title," one must continue to advance and learn, of course. As will be evident when we consider the reality of falling-in-love, the affective conversion that transforms a subject into a being-in-love, the commitment to moral perfection that we have discussed here is not a commitment to perfection for its own sake but for the sake of becoming a more authentic source of love dedicated to the ever greater realization of true value, especially the personal values of community and brotherhood.

Judgments and decisions sometimes occur in a context of growth, a context in which, says Lonergan, "one's knowledge of human living and operating is increasing in extent, precision, refinement, and in which one's responses are advancing from the agreeable to vital values, from vital to social, from social to cultural, from cultural to personal, from personal to religious. Then there prevails an openness to ever further achievement. ⁽⁹⁹⁾" In this context "one is responding to the transcendental notion of value, by determining what it would be worth while for one to make of oneself, and what it would be worth while to do for one's fellow men. One works out an ideal of human reality and achievement, and to that ideal one dedicates oneself. As one's knowledge increases, as one's experience is enriched, as one's reach is strengthened or weakened, one's ideal may be revised and the revision may occur many times. ⁽¹⁰⁰⁾"

But, as Professor Maslow points out, such continuous growth is rare. ⁽¹⁰¹⁾ Man, as Lonergan puts it in *Insight*, is plagued by moral impotence, an impotence measured by the gap between

⁽⁹⁷⁾ MT, p. 240.

⁽⁹⁸⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽⁹⁹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 39.

⁽¹⁰⁰⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 40.

⁽¹⁰¹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 39; see ABRAHAM MASLOW, *Towards a Psychology of Being* (Princeton, N.J.: D. Van Nostrand Company, 1962), p. 190.

his potential freedom and that which he actually possesses. ⁽¹⁰²⁾ Complete self-development, Lonergan points out, is a long and difficult process, and, as we have noted above, "during that process one has to live and make decisions in the light of one's undeveloped intelligence and under the guidance of one's incomplete willingness. ⁽¹⁰³⁾" Further, Lonergan reminds us, "the less developed one is, the less one appreciates the need of development and the less one is willing to take time for one's intellectual and moral education. ⁽¹⁰⁴⁾" So we have not only the "deviations occasioned by neurotic need," and the "refusals to keep on taking the plunge from settled routines to an as yet unexperienced but richer mode of living," but also "mistaken endeavors to quieten an uneasy conscience by ignoring, belittling, denying, rejecting higher values," distortion of preference scales, soured feelings, as well as the invasion of bias into one's outlook, "rationalization into one's morals, ideology into one's thought. ⁽¹⁰⁵⁾" And so, rather than responding to, one ignores the motives that lead to ever fuller authenticity, and one drifts into an ever less authentic selfhood. ⁽¹⁰⁶⁾

Now Lonergan is a theologian, or, at least a methodologist of theology; in any case, his fundamental concerns are theological. And, while it seems to me that these concerns in no way affect the validity of his basic philosophical analyses, it is not surprising that for him the rarity of continuous growth, the incapacity of men for sustained development, raises religious questions. One's judgments of value, decisions, choices, he says, are revealed by moral conversion as "the door to one's fulfilment or to one's loss. ⁽¹⁰⁷⁾" And « experience, especially repeated experience, of one's frailty or wickedness raises the question of one's salvation and, on a more fundamental level, there arises the question of God. ⁽¹⁰⁸⁾"

⁽¹⁰²⁾ *Insight*, p. 627.

⁽¹⁰³⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹⁰⁴⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹⁰⁵⁾ MT, pp. 39-40.

⁽¹⁰⁶⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 40.

⁽¹⁰⁷⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 39.

⁽¹⁰⁸⁾ *Ibid.*

RELIGIOUS CONVERSION AND LOVE

And, thus, according to Lonergan's analysis, beyond intellectual and moral conversion there is — also on the fourth level of responsible, existential consciousness — the possibility of religious conversion.

But what, according to Lonergan's perspective, is religious conversion? Lonergan's answer is given most simply and directly, I think, in the following passage:

Religious conversion is being grasped by ultimate concern. It is other-worldly falling in love. It is total and permanent self-surrender without conditions, qualifications, reservations. But it is such a surrender, not as an act, but as a dynamic state that is prior to and principle of subsequent acts. It is revealed in retrospect as an undertow of existential consciousness, as a fated acceptance of a vocation to holiness, as perhaps an increasing simplicity and passivity in prayer. It is interpreted differently in the context of different religious traditions. For Christians it is God's love flooding our hearts through the Holy Spirit given to us. It is the gift of grace, and since the days of Augustine, a distinction has been drawn between operative and cooperative grace. Operative grace is the replacement of the heart of stone by a heart of flesh, a replacement beyond the horizon of the heart of stone. Cooperative grace is the heart of flesh becoming effective in good works through human freedom. Operative grace is religious conversion. Cooperative grace is the effectiveness of conversion, the gradual movement towards a full and complete transformation of the whole of one's living and feeling, one's thoughts, words, deeds, and omissions ⁽¹⁰⁹⁾.

Like intellectual and moral conversion, religious conversion is a special modality, a fundamental form, a crucial instance of self-transcendence. While intellectual conversion is "to truth attained by cognitional self-transcendence", and moral conversion is "to values apprehended, affirmed, and realized by real self-transcendence," religious conversion, for Lonergan, is "to a total being-in-love as the efficacious ground of all self-transcendence, whether in the pursuit of truth, or in the realization of human

(¹⁰⁹) *Ibid.*, pp. 240-241.

values, or in the orientation man adopts to the universe, its ground, its goal. ⁽¹¹⁰⁾"

Thus, as forms of self-transcendence, intellectual, moral, and religious conversions, when found within one person's consciousness, may, says Lonergan, be understood to be related, like the various self-transcending operations of the different levels of consciousness, in terms of sublation. Following Karl Rahner's understanding of the term, ⁽¹¹¹⁾ Lonergan takes sublation to mean that what sublates — in this case the higher level conversion — "goes beyond what is sublated, introduces something new and distinct, puts everything on a new basis, yet so far from interfering with the sublated or destroying it, on the contrary needs it, includes it, preserves all its proper features and properties, and carries them forward to a fuller realization within a richer context. ⁽¹¹²⁾"

I think it should be clear from what we have seen of Lonergan's words that central to his understanding of religious conversion is the reality of love, a total, other-worldly, love of God "with all one's heart and all one's soul and all one's mind and all one's strength. ⁽¹¹³⁾" This love of God, of course, is not the only kind of love; and although other forms may not be total and otherworldly, they do, as Lonergan recognizes, have structural likenesses and play functionally similar roles in the human personality. In "Faith and Beliefs," Lonergan points out in his introductory remarks on religious involvement that "man's capacity for self-transcendence" becomes "achievement when one falls in love. ⁽¹¹⁴⁾" When one falls in love, he says, "one's being becomes being-in-love. ⁽¹¹⁵⁾" Now while it is true that "such being-in-love has its antecedents, its causes, its conditions, its occasions," still, once it has occurred and as long as it lasts, it takes over as first

⁽¹¹⁰⁾ *Ibid.* p. 241.

⁽¹¹¹⁾ See KARL RAHNER, *Hörer des Wortes* (Munich: Kösel, 1963), p. 40.

⁽¹¹²⁾ MT., p. 241. Lonergan's understanding of how intellectual, moral, and religious conversion are related to each other by sublation is explained in *Method in Theology*, pp. 241-242.

⁽¹¹³⁾ MT., p. 242.

⁽¹¹⁴⁾ "Faith and Beliefs", p. 9.

⁽¹¹⁵⁾ *Ibid.*

principle, and "from it flow one's desires and fears, one's joys and sorrows, one's discernment of values, one's decisions and deeds. ⁽¹¹⁶⁾" All this is true generally of being-in-love, and to this point we shall return quite soon. But, says Lonergan, "being-in-love is of different kinds. There is the love of intimacy, of husband and wife, of parents and children. There is the love of one's fellow men with its fruit in the achievement of human welfare. There is the love of God with one's whole heart and whole soul, with all one's mind and all one's strength. ⁽¹¹⁷⁾" And while all love is self-surrender, being-in-love with God is experienced as being-in-love in an "unrestricted" fashion, "without limits or qualifications or conditions or reservations. ⁽¹¹⁸⁾"

Perhaps because of his theological perspective, Lonergan, while recognizing the existence of non-religious love, almost never considers the reality of love outside of the religious context, and within that context the all but exclusive emphasis is on the love of God. One must go through nearly all of the almost eight-hundred pages of *Insight*, for example, before finding a few brief references to love, and then, again, these are to the theological virtue of love as part of a solution, along with hope and faith, to man's inherent condition of moral impotence. (Of course, by the time he wrote *Method in Theology*, Lonergan's appreciation of the reality of love had become more explicit.)

My point here is that while an explicitly theological ethics will want and need to include the reality of religious conversion and the love of God, a more general, philosophically grounded ethics, that though humanist is yet open-ended, will find great wealth in Lonergan's few and very brief remarks on being-in-love as the first principle of a person's horizon and the efficacious ground of all self-transcendence. What I am pointing to, then, is the reality of affective self-transcendence, of being-in-love, "as a dynamic state that is prior to and principle of subsequent acts. ⁽¹¹⁹⁾" Such a being-in-love brings about a transformation of

⁽¹¹⁶⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹¹⁷⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 9-10.

⁽¹¹⁸⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 10.

⁽¹¹⁹⁾ MT, p. 240.

one's horizon, one's world, one's very being, and so a transformation of the source of all one's discoveries, decisions, and deeds. Such being-in-love, then, is a real and basic conversion, and its depth and range are not to be predetermined. It can take many forms, from the gift of oneself to one other person to the gift one makes of oneself to all men in offering his total being to God. A philosophical, humanist ethic may not wish to presuppose God and his love, but if it is to be authentically open it must be ready to recognize that the self-transcending love of man has no necessary limits. Indeed, insofar as a religious outlook may be specified by its recognition and acceptance of life as a gift, even the most circumscribed love of man, if it be genuine self-surrender, can be considered as the beginning of religious conversion.

The basic point, though, is to build into one's ethical perspective an appreciation and analysis of the reality of love and its transforming power over all that man is and does, to provide a central location in one's ethical framework for affective self-transcendence, for the conversion to a being-in-love. For if moral conversion is essentially a challenge to an ever fuller, authentic development, affective conversion seems to constitute the concrete conditions for the possibility of successfully responding to that challenge. Indeed, we may say that in a very real sense only an affectively converted consciousness can be truly morally effective. Such an approach to the reality of love, affective self-transcendence and conversion seems to be clearly suggested, if not fully justified, by the way Lonergan leads up to a discussion of the other-worldly love of God in this passage from *Method in Theology*:

We noted that the human subject was self-transcendent intellectually by the achievement of knowledge, that he was self-transcendent morally inasmuch as he sought what was worth while, what was truly good, and thereby became a principle of benevolence and benefice, that he was self-transcendent affectively when he fell in love, when the isolation of the individual was broken and he spontaneously functioned not just for himself but for others as well ⁽¹²⁰⁾.

⁽¹²⁰⁾ *Ibid.* p. 289.

However, whether the far-reaching transformation of effective self-transcendence be considered as religious conversion to an other-worldly being-in-love, or, more generally, a conversion to a being-in-love of whatever kind, there remains the question of relating this conversion to the intellectual and moral conversions, and, indeed, of relating the intellectual and moral conversions to each other. We have seen that Lonergan explains these relationships — like those between different levels of consciousness — in terms of sublation. There is a difference, however. For, he states, “though religious conversion sublates moral, and moral conversion sublates intellectual, one is not to infer that intellectual comes first and then moral and finally religious”⁽¹²¹⁾ (as is true in the case of the sublating levels of consciousness, where experiential does come before the intelligent, the intelligent before the rational, etc., and this genetically as well as structurally). Rather, Lonergan claims that usually there first is religious conversion, followed by moral, and then, but only rarely, by intellectual conversion. He states his position this way in *Method in Theology*: “From a causal viewpoint, one would say that first there is God’s gift of his love. Next, the eye of this love reveals values in their splendor, while the strength of this love brings about their realization, and that is moral conversion. Finally”, he says, “among the values discerned by the eye of love is the value of believing the truths taught by the religious tradition, and in such tradition and belief are the seeds of intellectual conversion”⁽¹²²⁾. This is, at least, the usual order, says Lonergan⁽¹²³⁾.

This position, it seems to me, is not without difficulties. First of all, internally, only two pages before stating this order of religious, moral, and then intellectual conversion, Lonergan, relating them in terms of sublation (with the religious sublating the moral, and the moral the intellectual), said, as we noted, that the sublating conversion not only includes, preserves, and carries the sublated conversion forward to a fuller realization within a

⁽¹²¹⁾ *Ibid.* p. 243.

⁽¹²²⁾ *Ibid.*

⁽¹²³⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 267.

richer context, but also *needs* the sublated conversion ⁽¹²⁴⁾. Clearly, in the case of the successive levels of consciousness, each functions only in relation to the lower, sublated levels (one can understand only what one has experienced, etc.). So it is not easy to understand how Lonergan can assert an order of occurrence that has religious conversion preceding moral, and moral preceding intellectual, while at the same time claiming that as sublating, religious conversion *needs* the sublated moral and intellectual conversions, and as sublating, moral conversion *needs* the sublated intellectual conversion. (Based on Lonergan's own explication of sublation, this difficulty does not seem to be explained away by his claim that, contrary to the dictum, *nihil amatum nisi praecognitum*, "in religious matters love precedes knowledge" ⁽¹²⁵⁾).

Further, in asserting the order of occurrence as religious, moral, and then intellectual, Lonergan begins by stating that "from a causal viewpoint, one would say that first there is God's gift of his love" ⁽¹²⁶⁾. This may be true, but by Lonergan's own definition religious *conversion* seems primarily to be a loving, total self-surrender - in other words, a full *response* to "God's gift of his love". And if, as Lonergan would surely maintain, God offers his loving grace to all men, then it seems clear that some refuse to fully accept it. The difference between fully accepting and refusing or only partially responding to God's gift of his love, then, seems, on this definition, to distinguish the religiously converted man from other men ⁽¹²⁷⁾.

Of course, in Lonergan's theological perspective, God's grace plays a key role in moral and intellectual conversion, too. But

⁽¹²⁴⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 241.

⁽¹²⁵⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 122-123.

⁽¹²⁶⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 243.

⁽¹²⁷⁾ On the other hand, we have also seen that Lonergan identifies religious conversion with *operative* grace, MT, p. 241 - indeed, "habitual grace as operative", in "Bernard Lonergan Responds", in *Foundations of Theology: Papers from the International Lonergan Congress 1970*, ed by Philip McShane (Notre Dame, Indiana: University of Notre Dame Press, 1972), p. 226; but, again, Lonergan has recently said that by religious conversion he understands both "God's gift and man's acceptance of God's love", in "Bernard Lonergan Responds", in *Language Truth and Meaning: Papers from the International Lonergan Congress 1970*, ed by Philip McShane (Dublin: Gill and Macmillan, 1972), p. 308.

the love whose "eye" "reveals values in their splendor", and whose strength "brings about their realization", moral conversion, would appear to be the love that responds to God's gift of his love in religious conversion, not the gift itself⁽¹²⁸⁾. Indeed, Lonergan later does speak of "religious conversion as the *fruit* of God's gift of his grace" ⁽¹²⁹⁾. Moreover, in order for God's gracious love to be involved in intellectual as well as moral conversion, it does not seem necessary that they follow upon a *total* response to this love, religious conversion. In fact, Lonergan has drawn religious conversion in such full and deep colors that it does not seem to be a common occurrence at all; it seems, indeed, worlds apart from the religion of many pious churchgoers.

We have been considering religious conversion from two angles, that of cause, and that of effect. From the latter, it seems that, despite the number of religious people, religious conversion in Lonergan's sense is somewhat rare⁽¹³⁰⁾. (I do not mean to imply that religiously unconverted people in this sense are in no way religious, any more than intellectually and morally unconverted people are in no way reasonable knowers and responsible choosers). From the viewpoint of cause, then, it may well be that while God's gift of his love is first, man's loving and total response to that gift in religious conversion may be last, following intellectual and moral conversions.

However, it is still true that intellectual conversion is for Lonergan a rare phenomenon⁽¹³¹⁾; thus to say that religious conversion "needs" intellectual as well as moral conversion would make the religiously converted an elite group indeed. The same problem holds, of course, for the relationship between moral and intellectual conversion; does moral conversion "need" intellectual conversion⁽¹³²⁾, or does intellectual conversion normally follow upon moral conversion as its fruit? ⁽¹³³⁾, Moral conversion,

⁽¹²⁸⁾ MT, p. 243.

⁽¹²⁹⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 268; my underlining.

⁽¹³⁰⁾ See Maslow, *Towards a Psychology of Being*, p. 190; and MT, p. 39.

⁽¹³¹⁾ "Bernard Lonergan Responds", in *Foundations of Theology*, p. 234.

⁽¹³²⁾ MT, p. 241.

⁽¹³³⁾ *Ibid.*, p. 267.

like religious, is not, of course, something that one simply falls into, but should we say that it is restricted to the elite of the intellectually converted?

While the solution I will now propose pertains to all three conversions, the religious as well as the moral and intellectual, I will emphasize the relationship between the intellectual and the moral conversions, inasmuch as the nature of the moral conversion is our primary interest in this paper. My proposed solution involves, on the one hand, a distinction between a *critical* moral (and religious) conversion and an *uncritical* moral (and religious) conversion, and, on the other, a distinction between a fully *explicated*, philosophical intellectual conversion and a more *implicit* but nonetheless real intellectual conversion.

Most simply, as we have seen, moral conversion is that shift in "criterion of one's decisions and choices from satisfactions to values" ⁽¹³⁴⁾. But this shift in criterion, it seems, can be made critically or uncritically; that is, one can *critically* recognize and accept the responsibility of critically discovering and establishing his own values for himself (in dialogue with his community), or one may merely turn *uncritically* toward and accept a *given* set of values, be they given by parents, church, peers, "society", or whomever. Moral conversion in this second uncritical sense seems to be a real enough conversion (from satisfaction to values), but it presupposes no intellectual conversion, and could follow very easily, or so it seems, from religious motivation. (The second or conventional level of Kohlberg's schema seems to illustrate this kind of uncritical concern for value quite well). Moral consciousness that is converted in this uncritical way sublates the empirical, intelligent, and rational levels of consciousness, but these levels as intellectually unconverted. In general, it seems more accurate to speak of one level (converted or unconverted) subsuming another or others (converted or not) than of one "conversion" subsuming another "conversion".

If we add to the shift in criterion, however, the existential moment when we discover for ourselves "that it is up to each of

(¹³⁴) *Ibid.*, p. 240.

us to decide for himself what he is to make of himself" ⁽¹³⁵⁾, there seems to result a truly critical moral conversion, for the phrases "up to each of us to decide for himself what he is to make of himself" seems to suppose at least what I would call an *implicit* intellectual conversion, that is, a subject's tacit realization of himself as the criterion of the real and the truly good in his own self-transcending judgments and choices of value. I say "at least implicit» because while such a fully critical moral conversion could follow upon a fully articulated philosophical version of intellectual conversion, it seems that the implicit or tacit intellectual realization spelled out above is a necessary and sufficient condition for a critical moral conversion. And given the rarity of philosophically articulated intellectual conversion, this implicit intellectual conversion (which, though hardly a common phenomenon, is less rare, I think, than Lonergan's strictly philosophical conversion) would seem to be the usual basis for a critically grounded moral conversion.

Such a differentiation between a critical and an uncritical moral conversion seems to be clearly justified in terms of Lonergan's own analysis of the basic structure of conscious operations. For, basically, moral conversion is a decision or choice on the fourth level of consciousness, a choice of value over satisfaction as criterion for decisions, and a choice of oneself as responsible. And this choice, like any other, is just as good - no more, no less - as the understanding and judgment from which it proceeds and on which it depends. We have already noted above that the fourth level of consciousness itself involves two moments, two different kinds of responses: judgment of value, and decision or choice. While it may not always be easy to distinguish judgments of value from judgments of fact, one can distinguish decisions or choices from judgments, and one's decisions will be critical insofar as they proceed from judgment, authentic insofar as they conform to objective judgment. Thus a moral conversion proceeding from an intelligent grasp and reasonable

(135) *Ibid.*

affirmation of one's own interiority is a truly critical self-appropriation. Moral conversion as a mere shift in criterion for decision from satisfaction to value, on the other hand, lacks fundamental self-knowledge, and, while adequate perhaps for getting along in untroubled times, is vulnerable to exploitation from every side, and, because its values are held uncritically, is like a ship without captain or rudder during stormy times. The fact of the matter is that critical self-appropriation is no luxury; it is an essential part of authentic human living. (And insofar as most religious conversions have a moral aspect, they too will be defenseless against all challengers if uncritical, not to mention the internal enemy, man's proclivity to mythmaking. But religious conversion, too, besides being uncritical, may follow upon not only a philosophically articulated intellectual conversion and full self-appropriation, but also the critical self-appropriation that involves an implicit intellectual conversion).

Intellectual conversion is of great importance for making fundamental clarifications in fields like philosophy of science, philosophy of history, theological method, to name only a few, but its really crucial significance is to be found in the kind of personal, existential self-appropriation that we have been discussing, the appropriation of oneself as a free, responsible, and self-constituting originator of value who in his self-transcending judgments and choices is the criterion of the real and the truly good. And in this area, the basic realization, more than its technical philosophical expression, seems to be of paramount importance, for the breakthrough that dispels the myth of knowing as taking a look and of reality as the already-out-there-now need be only as technical as the myth's own expression. In most people, the myth is spontaneous and without technical articulation, so the conversion that overcomes it need not match in explanatory power and sophistication the philosophical position of, say, a Hume or a Kant. For such people, an intellectual conversion implicit within a fuller moral conversion would seem to be sufficient.

Indeed, moral conversion would seem to be not only a possible, but also a very natural and highly likely context for such an intellectual conversion. For, clearly, nothing is closer,

more personal to the subject than his own decisions and choices, and thus the reflection, deliberation and evaluation leading up to them. And if the choice is more important than the flavor of ice cream for tonight's dessert or of more personal concern than the make of a new automobile, the centrality of one's subjectivity can be exposed in a sometimes all too harsh fashion, for one finds it difficult to surround oneself with the defenses of "objective" criteria when one faces personal decisions about the military draft, aborting a fetus, or withholding the means of life from an incurably sick, elderly parent suffering unendurable pain; or when one decides on a spouse, or a career, or must choose between marriage and career. Because one does not want to decide or choose blindly, without reflection, and because in one's attempts at intelligent and reasonable reflection, one usually discovers before too long that there are neither easy, simple answers to concrete questions of life and death nor a predetermined, easy-to-follow program for one's life somewhere "out there" to be hit upon if only one looks long and hard enough. This discovery, what Lonergan calls an "inverse insight" ⁽¹³⁶⁾, that no pre-packaged life scripts or solutions to human problems exist, and that the pursuit of them leads one into the maze of endless blind alleys of unauthentic decisions, has the singular power of leading one to the positive discovery of oneself, in the authentic, self-transcending insights, judgments, decisions, and choices of one's own subjectivity, as the only truly objective source and criterion of human meaning and value. I must emphasize that this intellectual conversion is implicit *not* in the sense that one accidentally and almost without noticing falls upon it during the course of life, but in the sense that it occurs along with, within, and as part of a moral conversion upon which attention is focused. Insofar as this happens, the focal conversion is not simply a moral shift, but also a critical self-appropriation.

Such an implicit intellectual conversion forms an adequately critical ground for a full moral conversion whose shift in criteria for decisions will be to the appropriation of personally discovered

⁽¹³⁶⁾ *Insight*, pp. 19-25.

and developed values rather than to an uncritical conformity with a moral code or set of values given by some external authority. But it is not in any strict sense a philosophical conversion, and would have to be developed and expressed in a technical fashion in order to be employed in the work of philosophical analysis. Despite its non-philosophical character, however, I have departed from Lonergan's analysis of conversion in order to develop this notion of implicit conversion because it seems necessary for the analysis proper to foundational ethics, where conversion plays a dual role. For conversion (both intellectual and moral as well as affective) is crucial to foundational ethics not only in the strictly philosophical, systematic and technical sense inasmuch as those doing foundational ethics must be critically self-appropriated in order to grasp correct basic philosophical positions, break the fundamental myths on knowing, objectivity, and reality, and establish the ethical enterprise on authentic grounds. It is also crucial in the sense of an implicit intellectual conversion within moral (and affective) conversion that I have introduced, inasmuch as personal conversion is a principal object of analysis in foundational ethics, where conscience is a paramount reality. And it is explicitly to conscience, finally, that we must now turn our attention.

CONSCIENCE

The radical meaning of human conscience, I am suggesting, is the reality of the authentic personal subject, intellectually, morally, and affectively converted, operating on the fourth and highest level of moral, responsible, existential consciousness. Such an understanding, of course, is nominative; other meanings of conscience must be understood in terms of it.

Do all adults have a conscience in this radical, fully human sense of conscience? Now that we have considered the phenomenon of conversion, we may think of conscience as either merely potential (before moral conversion) or actual (after moral conversion). And this actualized (normative) conscience will be critical or not depending on the nature of the moral conversion,

as we have seen. Within this framework, the term "religious conscience" may refer to either potential or actual conscience, before or after religious conversion. In any case, the designation "religious" specifies not the functional or structural aspect of conscience, but the nature of the ground which supports and the matrix which shapes one's judgments and choices of value. In so far as conversion transforms one's whole orientation and being, the source and principle from which flow the judgments and decisions of the religiously converted man has little if anything in common with that of the unconverted man. I must repeat here, however, something we saw earlier with Lonergan, namely, that genuine religious conversion, while giving a new basis to conscience, in no way violates or destroys the integrity of conscience ⁽¹³⁷⁾.

For Lonergan, conscience is a form of consciousness. Specifically, conscience is the consciousness of the fourth level - or, as he variously refers to it, "rational self", moral, responsible, existential consciousness ⁽¹³⁸⁾. But this, I must emphasize again, is the fourth level of consciousness *as distinct* from the other levels taken by themselves, but *not as separated* from the other three levels. For, as I have tried to highlight before, each successive level of consciousness *sublates* the lower level, so that the subject on the fourth level of consciousness is *at once* empirically, intelligently, rationally, *and* morally conscious. Thus, to say that a person is morally or responsibly conscious means that he is also empirically, intelligently, and rationally conscious. The higher level complements, presupposes, and includes the lower levels.

Further, to say that conscience is the fourth level of moral consciousness (sublating the lower three levels) means that conscience is the subject himself as morally conscious, for, indeed, consciousness is constitutive of the human person as subject. When this consciousness is moral, responsible, existential, the subject is both constituted and revealed to himself at the peak,

⁽¹³⁷⁾ MT, p. 242.

⁽¹³⁸⁾ See "Faith and Beliefs", p. 9; MT, p. 268; and *Insight*, pp. 610 and 628.

the highest intensity of his subjectivity. Most fundamentally, then, this is the critical meaning of the assertion that man does not have, but *is* a conscience.

To thus identify conscience with moral consciousness, i.e., with the *subject* as morally conscious, is to reject the various attempts that have been made to equate conscience with some particular faculty or power or act of the person.

The continuity and unity of human consciousness as analyzed by Lonergan is, quite simply, directly opposed to a faculty psychology⁽¹³⁹⁾. What is presented to consciousness, he shows, is not a collection of faculties or powers, but a set of interrelated operations, which, in Lonergan's words, together

conspire to achieve both cognitional and real self-transcendence. Such is the basic unity and continuity. No part of the process can be dispensed with, for each has its essential contribution to make. To achieve the good, one has to know the real. To know the real, one has to reach the truth. To reach the truth one has to understand, to grasp the intelligible. To grasp the intelligible, one has to attend to the data. Each successive level of operations presupposes and complements its predecessors. The topmost level is the level of deliberate control and self-control; there consciousness becomes conscience; there operations are authentic in the measure that they are responses to value⁽¹⁴⁰⁾.

In the same way, it becomes clear that conscience cannot be reduced to any single act or operation, such as decision, choice, or, as has often been the case, judgment of a particular kind. For moral consciousness sublates all the previous levels of intentional operations, and so depends on them. Conscience, then, involves all the subject's conscious and intentional operations insofar as they are practical, heading toward decision and action.

Moral consciousness is highlighted, however, by the manifestation of man's drive toward self-transcendence in the form of an exigence for consistence between one's knowing and one's

⁽¹³⁹⁾ See "Faith and Beliefs", pp. 8-9; and MT, pp. 268-269, 340 and 343.

⁽¹⁴⁰⁾ "Faith and Beliefs", p. 9.

doing, for conformity of one's decisions to one's reasonable, objective judgments. And this exigence, standing between knowledge and decision, while concretizing the meaning of freedom, obligation, and responsibility, is perhaps, the crystallization of the meaning of conscience. In other words, conscience is the dynamic thrust toward self-transcendence at the core of man's very subjectivity revealing itself on the fourth level of consciousness as a demand for responsible decision in accord with reasonable judgment. As such, it points in two directions, to what I call the two key ethical moments: knowing and deciding. As a drive for self-transcendence, conscience insists on responsible, that is to say, authentic decisions and choices. But, because moral consciousness is itself an enlargement and transformation of the rational consciousness of the third level (whereby rational necessity is transformed into the rational exigence that is obligation), a decision or choice can be responsible and authentic only insofar as it is reasonable, that is, consistent with reasonable judgment. Thus, if decision is to be responsible, judgment itself must be reasonable, truly critical. And most of all, this means *self-critical*. An "easy conscience" is very probably the most personally disastrous way men fail in their obligation to critical questioning. Human authenticity has no room for complacency, self-satisfaction. The subject who would be authentic must engage himself in a continual process of constantly checking, expanding, and deepening his understanding through a critical exchange with the most informed and sensitive members of his widest community. This self-criticism, of course, must include not only a thorough, on-going check of one's grasp of human reality and situations, but also and most significantly, a ruthless critique of one's moral feelings, one's responses to values of various kinds. Only such a critical quest for authentic understanding and feeling can ground the real self-transcendence of a truly human conscience ⁽¹⁴¹⁾.

⁽¹⁴¹⁾ See *Insight*, pp. 599-600 where Lonergan discusses man's attempts to dodge the moral exigence through the avoidance of self-consciousness, rationalization, and moral renunciation.

Because conscience is intrinsically constituted by a context of understanding and feeling that is in a process of developing toward even greater or less authenticity, it is obvious that not only will conscience - in the concrete - mean something quite different from subject to subject (as does, say, accumulated experience or habitual understanding), but an important aspect of this difference will be varying degrees of authenticity. In other words, even before we get to the question about a subject's authenticity in his attempt to conform decision to judgment - the degree, for example, of his habitual willingness - there is the question about the authenticity of the subject's conscience, of the entire matrix of understanding, feeling, and judgments that forms the context of each practical judgment of value.

Conscience, in short, is not some given constant of the human person, something which everyone has, period. Rather, human subjects are empirically, intelligently, rationally, and morally conscious, and that consciousness takes endlessly multiple, variant forms in the concrete, each more or less authentic. Therefore there is the need for a *normative* interpretation of conscience. While it may be true that a man must follow his own conscience, and I for one think it is, it will not be enough on that symbolic day of judgment for a man to say, simply, "I followed my conscience", for as we have noted, he will surely be asked not only how faithfully he *followed his* conscience, but also how authentically he *formed* it.

Lonergan has touched upon the normative aspect of conscience in the notion of a "good conscience", the result of conversion. On this point he states, in *Method in Theology*, that "decision is responsible and it is free, but it is the work not of a metaphysical will but of conscience and, indeed, when a conversion, the work of a good conscience" ⁽¹⁴²⁾. Such a "good conscience" is itself the criterion of judgments of value, for, says Lonergan,

such judgments are felt to be true or false in so far as they generate a peaceful or uneasy conscience. But they attain their

(142) MT, p. 269.

proper context, their clarity and refinement, only through man's historical development and the individual's personal appropriation of his social, cultural, and religious heritage. It is by the transcendental notion of value and its expression in a good and uneasy conscience that man can develop morally. But a rounded moral judgment is ever the work of a fully developed self-transcending subject or, as Aristotle would put it, of a virtuous man ⁽¹⁴³⁾.

Such a "good conscience", I am proposing, should be recognized as the only conscience one can appeal to for moral authority. Such a "good conscience", in other words, should be considered as definitive of the primary meaning of conscience. Man's very dynamism for self-transcendence dictates that he be defined not in terms common to any man, but in terms of the man who has achieved the authenticity of normative development. Thus conscience, which is essentially a matter of value—indeed, the criterion of value—should be defined not just as moral consciousness that has transformed itself by shifting the criterion of its decisions and choices from satisfactions to values. It is right that each person should be able to take his stand on his own conscience, uncoerced by external force. But everyone who does so should also recognize that appeals to conscience do not automatically or necessarily make one right, that some consciences are more authentic than others, and that one's commitment to his "conscience" must always remain critical. Sincerity to what one feels deeply about, or spontaneously "thinks best", in other words, is not enough. Sincerity must be fully and continually self-critical if it is to be authentic. For such self-criticism, of course, a radical openness to other viewpoints is a pre-requisite; and such openness seems to have its necessary condition in a deep sense of humility.

While everyone has a "conscience" in the sense that every normal man has some degree of moral sense, some depth of moral consciousness, I am suggesting on the basis of our present analysis that the primary, basic, normative meaning of conscience be understood as at least the consciousness of morally conver-

⁽¹⁴³⁾ *Ibid.*, pp. 40-41.

ted person, and optimally that consciousness as also critically appropriated and affectively converted. In other words, I am proposing that we understand conscience in the fully human sense as being proper to and distinguishing the person who has taken possession of himself critically as a free and responsible creator and has opted for value over satisfaction as a criterion for decision and choice - the person who is a source of love, a principle of benevolence and beneficence because his very being is a being-in-love. Conscience, then, in a few words, should be understood as the fundamental, dynamic reality of the personal subject who has committed, dedicated, indeed, surrendered himself to the radical demands of the human spirit: be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible, love⁽¹⁴⁵⁾. Quite simply, conscience is the fullest expression of man's fundamental exigence for full self-transcendence. A foundational ethics capable of accurately interpreting the reality of the human person needs such an understanding of conscience as self-transcendence.

WALTER CONN, PH. D.
St. Patrick's Seminary
Menlo Park, Calif. U.S.A.

(144) *Ibid.*, pp. 253 and 268.